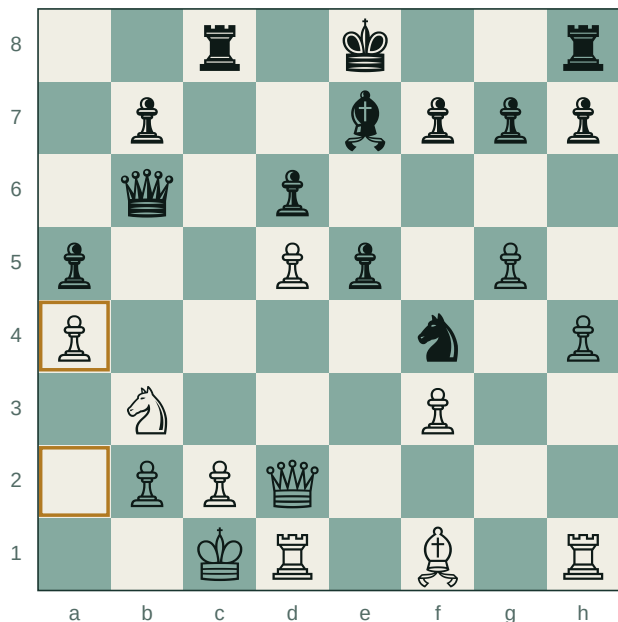


Active defensive resources: Black, move 17

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 17.a4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17...Qxb3 18. Bb5+ Kf8

17...Qxb3 The queen captures the knight on b3. Recorded reply: **18.Bb5+**.

18...Kf8 The king moves from e8 to f8.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 32 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on c1. Absolute pin: pawn on c2.